

Session 36: Jonah’s One-Day Walk Into Nineveh

Key Takeaways

- “A walking of three days” echoes Jonah’s three days inside the fish. The city of Nineveh is named after a goddess whose name means “fish.”
- Jonah’s disobedience lands him in a fish for three days, and his obedience lands him in the fish city for three days. But he actually only spends one day in the city.
- Jonah is a complex and often ambiguous story. It’s helpful to keep the interpretive possibilities open as we read as biblical narratives often use intentional gaps and ambiguities to compel us to participate in the discovery of meaning.

Jonah’s Sermon and Nineveh’s Response: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 3:1-10

A	3:1-4 God’s Actions Toward Nineveh through Jonah The word of Yahweh came to Jonah ... "call out the message that I speak to you.”		
B	a	3:5 The Ninevites Respond And the Ninevites believed in God and called a fast, and clothed with sackcloth .	
	b	3:6 The King of Nineveh Responds He arose from his throne ... covered with sackcloth ... and sat in the dust.	
	a	3:7-9 The King’s Edict to the Ninevites “Don’t eat anything ... or drink water ... cover with sackcloth ... turn from his evil way.”	
A	3:10 God Responds to the Ninevites Actions And God saw their actions ... and he repented of the evil which he spoke to do to them.		
Jonah’s Sermon and Nineveh’s Response. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).			

Observations About This Design

The outer frame (A and A’) focuses on God’s action in confronting Nineveh and then responding to their response. The inner section (B) consist of three scenes of repenting, each intensifying the drastic response from (I) all the people to (II) the king, (III) and the king’s edict to all of the people.

A ¹ And the **word of Yahweh** was to Jonah a second time, saying:
 B ² "Arise, go to **Nineveh the great city** ,
 C and **call out** to it the calling-out which **I am speaking** to you."
 B' ³ And Jonah arose and he went to **Nineveh** ,
 A' according to the **word of Yahweh** .

I Now, Nineveh was a great city to God,
 II **a walking of** three **days** .
 I' ⁴ And Jonah began to go into the **city**
 II' **a walking** of one **day** ,
 III and **he called out** , and he said,
 IV "Forty days, and Nineveh is overturned."

Jonah 3:1-4. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

3:1-3a is symmetrically designed with a focus on Yahweh's word and speech. All forms of the Hebrew word דבר punctuate the opening, middle, and concluding lines (A, C, A').

3:3b-4 is designed as a stair-step series.

- I and II introduce Nineveh's metaphorical greatness to God, followed by its physical greatness in size.
- I' shows Jonah going by God's commission to the great city.
- II' shows his entrance into the city.

But notice the difference between II and II'. We're told that the city was "three day's walking," but then we learn that Jonah only walked "one day's walking" into the city. This disconnect between God's command and Jonah's response should alert our suspicions that all is not well in Jonah's response.

"Nineveh Was a City Great to God"

Jonathan Magonet (*Form and Meaning*, 32-33) discusses this as one of many "growing phrases" in the book. This is a technique of thematic repetition that adds words to phrases as they appear throughout the book, each addition giving further clarification to the theme's significance in the book.

Jonah 1:2 NASB

Go to Nineveh, the great city

Jonah 3:2 NASB

Go to Nineveh, the great city

Jonah 3:3 NASB*

And Nineveh was a great city to God

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah 4:11 ESV*

Shouldn't I have pity on Nineveh, the great city, which has in it more than 120,000 people ... ?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"At first we know only of Nineveh's size and its wickedness that has arisen to God ... But when in chapter 3 Jonah comes to the city, then it is revealed as being a great city "to God." As yet we don't know whether this only concerns its great evil (as in 1:2) and its imminent punishment, or if the phrase implies some other relationship to God. It's only in chapter 4, which ends with God's question, that the fullness of the implications of the city's relationship to God and even its size is spelled out: the myriads who don't know their right from left hand and all their cattle."

Magonet, Jonathan (1983). [*Form and Meaning: Studies in Literary Techniques in the Book of Jonah*](#). Almond Press. 32-33.

"Three Days Walking"

"About Nineveh's size, Bewer (1912: 50–52) gives ample citations from classical sources, most of which accentuate its inordinate size. R. D. Barnett (1968) and L. C. Allen (1976: 221–22) refer to archaeological and cuneiform sources showing that at its zenith Nineveh was about three miles on its widest axis, almost eight miles in circumference, and occupied about 1,850 acres. Because in a three-day march individuals normally cover thirty to forty miles, some scholars imagine that the narrator is referring to 'greater' Nineveh, that is, the city and its outlying territories and cities (as in [Genesis 10:11-12](#)). Be that as it may, we are not likely to gain much by testing the validity of Jonah's 'three-day walk/journey' against Nineveh's actual dimensions. 'Three-day' merely establishes that a large space separates two positions (see especially [Gen 30:36](#) and [Exod 3:18](#)). Strikingly similar in vocabulary and spirit is the way the Greeks remembered Babylon's size. Herodotus tells us (1.191) that it took a long time before news reached the town's center that the Persians had captured Babylon's fortifications. Aristotle apparently embellishes the same tradition by specifying that the city 'had been taken for three days before some part of the inhabitants became aware of the fact.' In Jonah, the phrase also prepares us to learn about Nineveh's immense population (4:11). More immediately, however, 'three-day walk' sets up an obvious contrast with the 'one-day walk' of the next."

Sasson, Jack M. (1995). [Jonah](#). Yale University Press. 230-231.

The mention of "three days" also recalls Jonah's three days and three nights in the belly of the fish. In fact, in popular Akkadian (the Semitic dialect used in ancient Assyria), the name "Nineveh" sounds like "Nina," a river goddess symbolized by a fish.

"If the thesis of a link between the name of the city and the fish is correct, the story incorporates an ironic play on words that enhances readers' enjoyment: Jonah tries to flee in the opposite direction, to get as far as possible from 'Fish City' and avoid performing his mission. But the Lord intervenes and sees to it that he winds up in a fish all the same—first a marine creature and then the metropolis."

Shemesh, Yael (2010). "'And Many Beasts' (Jonah 4:11): The Function and Status of Animals in the Book of Jonah." *Journal of Hebrew Scriptures*, vol 10. 12.

Reflection Question

In the beginning of Jonah 3, we read that “Nineveh was a going of three days.” But we also read that Jonah goes into the city “one day.” The biblical authors are intentional and selective about what they include in their stories. What are some possible reasons for the author’s inclusion of this detail? What might the author want us to understand?